



— YOUR GUIDE TO CLOSING UP

# Leaving your Spanish home for the winter

What to switch off, what to leave on and what to pay before you lock the door, so you come back to a home exactly as you left it.

**BUENO** | PROPERTY  
SIMPLIFIED

# Heading home for the winter?

A home that sits closed for weeks or months needs a little preparation. Most of the expensive surprises owners find in spring start with something small that nobody was there to see. This guide walks you through the checks that matter, in the order that matters.

## The essentials at a glance

- Water damage is the most expensive thing that happens to an empty home, so the water goes off first.
- Someone who can check on the home turns a small problem into a quick fix.
- Bills keep arriving while you are away, so the account they come from must stay funded.



# Start with the water

One tap failing behind a wall while nobody is there is the single most expensive thing that happens to empty Spanish homes.

## 01 Turn off the main stopcock

The llave de paso is usually near the meter or under the kitchen sink. Then open every tap for a few seconds to take the pressure off the pipes.

DO THIS FIRST

## 02 Switch off the water heater

A termo left heating an empty tank for three months costs money and shortens its life. Check under the sinks and behind the washing machine for damp while you are there.

## 03 Decide what stays on before you touch the fuse box

The alarm, the router and any light timers need power. Unplug everything else, which also protects it from storm surges.

## 04 Empty the fridge and freezer

For a long absence, defrost, clean and leave the doors propped open. A power cut you never hear about turns a full freezer into a smell that will not come out.

LONG ABSENCES

# Keep the air moving and the visitors out

A closed Spanish home over winter can become humid, and an empty kitchen is an open invitation to ants and cockroaches. A few small steps prevent both.

## **Leave the inside doors open**

Open interior and wardrobe doors so air moves through the whole home, and pull furniture a few centimetres away from outside walls, where mould usually starts.

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## **Put out moisture absorbers**

Place them in the bathroom, the wardrobes and any north-facing room. They cost very little and are some of the cheapest protection you can buy.

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## **Seal the drains with a little oil**

Pour a little cooking oil into every drain and toilet bowl. It floats on the water and slows evaporation, so the seal in the pipe stays full and insects cannot climb up a dry drain. Close the toilet lids too.

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## **Leave nothing for pests to find**

Take the rubbish off the property, not just to the terrace, and put flour, rice, cereal and pet food into sealed containers or take them with you.

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## **Ask about building works**

In an apartment, ask the administrador de fincas to tell you about any roof or terrace works. Work above your flat while you are away is a common cause of water damage that owners find out about far too late.

# Make it look lived in

A home that visibly nobody visits is the one that gets tried. These steps cost little and make a real difference.

## 01 Find someone who can check on it

A neighbour, the community president or a key holder. Give them a key, your number and written permission to enter, and ask for a dated photo each time they look in.

THE BIGGEST DIFFERENCE

## 02 Use light timers and leave the shutters partly down

Set timers in two rooms on different schedules. Shutters that stay fully closed for weeks tell everyone the owner is away.

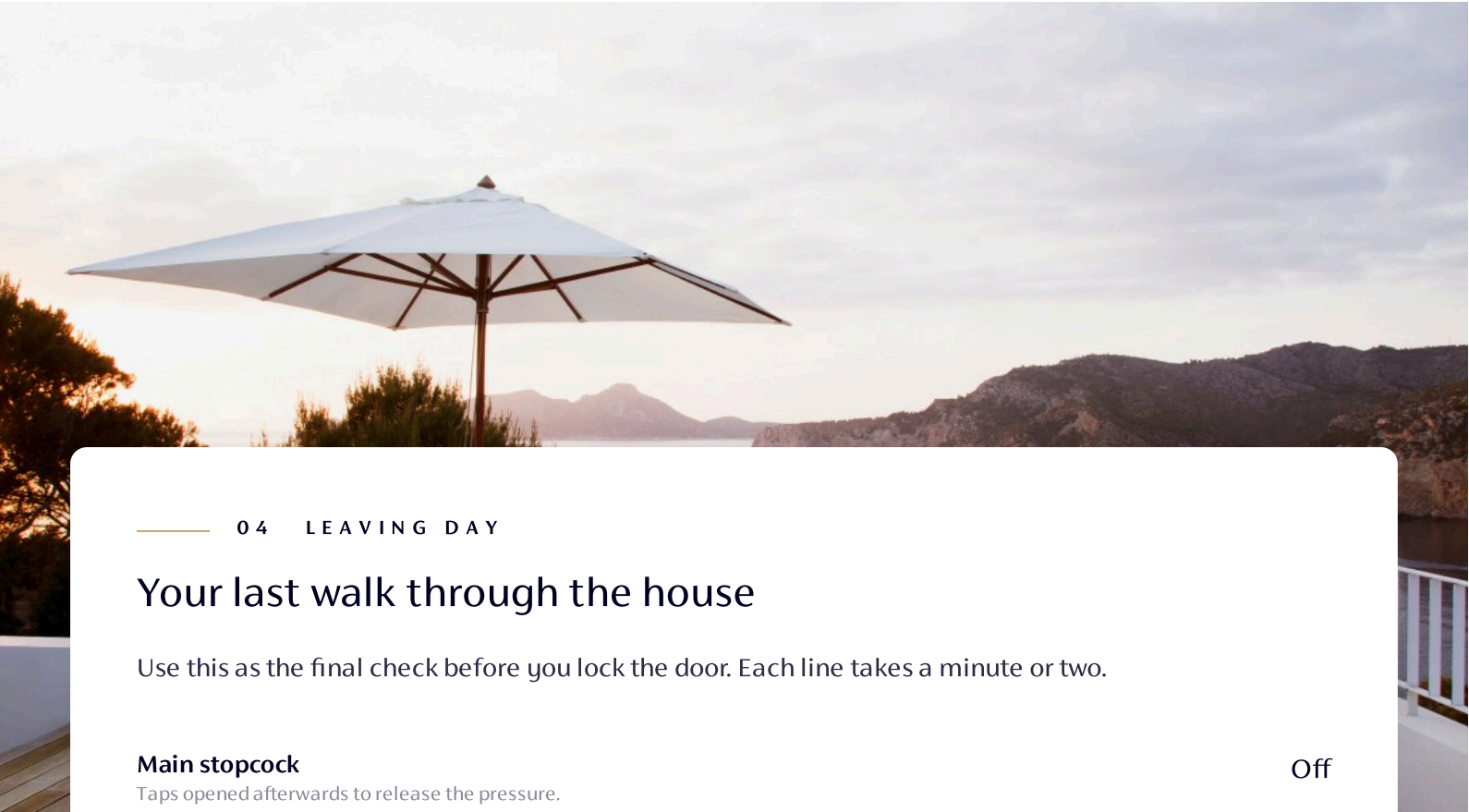
## 03 Photograph every room and the meters

Keep the photos where you can reach them from abroad. They show the state you left the home in, that it is a home you use, and they settle any argument about a bill.

## 04 Check your insurance covers an empty home

Many policies limit or exclude cover after a stated number of days unoccupied. Find that number in your policy before you rely on it.

READ THE SMALL PRINT



04 LEAVING DAY

## Your last walk through the house

Use this as the final check before you lock the door. Each line takes a minute or two.

|                                                                                |         |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| <b>Main stopcock</b><br>Taps opened afterwards to release the pressure.        | Off     |
| <b>Water heater</b><br>Switched off at the mains.                              | Off     |
| <b>Fridge and freezer</b><br>Empty, clean, doors propped open.                 | Off     |
| <b>Alarm, router and light timers</b><br>Alerts tested from outside the house. | On      |
| <b>Drains and toilets</b><br>A little oil in each, lids closed.                | Sealed  |
| <b>Account balance</b><br>Enough for every direct debit until you return.      | Checked |

Last thing before you go

Photos taken

# The bills do not stop while you are away

Power, water, the community and the town hall keep sending bills through the winter. These checks make sure every one of them is paid.

## **Keep the direct debit account funded**

A returned direct debit for water or power is how supply gets cut, and reconnecting from abroad is slow and costly.

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## **Bring the community fee up to date**

In Spain, community debt is attached to the property itself, so it follows the home and it follows a sale.

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## **Know when your IBI is due**

Each town hall sets its own payment period for the local property tax, and many collect it in the second half of the year. Paying by direct debit means the bill is settled even if the letter never reaches you.

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## **Make sure your card works abroad**

A card blocked for unusual activity while you travel can also stop the payments linked to it. Check your contact details and notifications before you go.

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## **Note your Modelo 210 deadline**

If you do not rent your home out, last year's non-resident return is due by 31 December. To pay it by direct debit, it must be filed by 23 December.

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# Three things to keep an eye on this winter

## Your IBI period

Set by your town hall. The dates are printed on your IBI bill, the recibo.

## 23 December

Last day to file your Modelo 210 for a home that is not rented out and pay it by direct debit.

## 31 December

Final deadline for that return if you pay it any other way.

## If a tax bill goes unpaid

This applies to local taxes such as the IBI as well as to national tax. The sooner an unpaid bill is settled, the smaller the surcharge.

5%

If you pay the whole debt after the deadline but before you receive the formal demand for payment.

10%

If you pay within the period given in that formal demand.

20%

If you pay after that period, plus late-payment interest, and the debt can then be collected from your account or registered against the property.

# Let the bills look after themselves

Bueno gives you a Spanish IBAN built for owners who live elsewhere, so everything your home needs can be paid while you are away.

- 01 Your IBI, community fees and utility bills are paid by direct debit.
- 02 You see every payment in the app, wherever you are.
- 03 Our multilingual team explains any letter your home receives.
- 04 We can file your Modelo 210 for you before the deadline.

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